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Empathy, Blue-Collar Marketing & the AI Silver Lining

A conversation with Benjamin Behrooz on empathy, visibility, the trades, and using AI without letting it use you.

Host Jeremy Rivera sits down with Benjamin Behrooz — founder of the Branding agency network across Los Angeles, NYC, Texas, Miami, and Aloha, and creator of the real-estate startup noagentlist.com.

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Benjamin: brandinglosangeles.com · The show: unscriptedseo.com

WHAT'S INSIDE

Six ideas from the episode

- 01** Empathy is the skill AI can't fake
- 02** The front office of visibility
- 03** Blue-collar is the future
- 04** Market on the customer's terms — not your ego
- 05** noagentlist.com — the Robin Hood of real estate
- 06** The AI silver lining

A NOTE FROM THE SHOW

Benjamin Behrooz has spent seventeen years building brands in five markets, and he walked into this conversation with one throughline: market on the customer's terms, do genuine good, and let AI surface your real history instead of thinking for you. This companion distills the episode into the six ideas most worth stealing — whether you run an agency, a home-services crew, or a two-year-old mom-and-pop that never got on the bullhorn.

CHAPTER 01

Empathy is the skill AI can't fake

Fresh off a trade show, Benjamin kept circling one word: empathy. He'd just sat across from Morgan & Morgan — a firm taking in some 75,000 leads a week — and what they harped on wasn't automation. It was their deliberate refusal to let AI run intake, because AI strips out the empathy that makes a hurting person feel heard.

"It's not businesses, it's people, it's their dreams."

— Benjamin Behrooz

Benjamin's own version is quieter. He once told a mom-and-pop apparel brand they weren't a fit yet, handed them a two-or-three-step roadmap, and sent them on their way. Three years later they came back ready to grow — "You're still here?" "We're still here." The lesson he keeps returning to is that you're never really selling to a business at all.

CHAPTER 02

The front office of visibility

Ask Benjamin what's missing from most business plans and he doesn't hesitate: the front office. He walks into two-year-old mom-and-pops with a strong back office — good work, solid Google and Yelp reviews — who simply never got on the bullhorn to tell anyone. They're booked two days a week when they could be booked out for months.

“Turn it off. We have too many leads. We're booked out for the next three to four months.”

— Benjamin Behrooz

That gap is where a marketer adds rocket-ship growth. The one variable he can't control is the owner's demeanor, so before signing anyone he checks something unglamorous but decisive: are they actually nice people? When a good back office finally meets real visibility, the phone stops being the problem and starts being the reward.

CHAPTER 03

Blue-collar is the future

Benjamin is blunt about where the money is going. AI can't climb onto a roof, rewire a panel, or unclog a drain — so he's convinced the next wave of millionaires will be blue-collar trades. The catch is that everyone now knows it, which makes home services one of the most inundated markets around.

“AI can't fix your roof, it can't fix your door — you can't AI-zap something to fix your electricity or your plumbing. So we know the future millionaires of this country are gonna be blue-collar workers.”

— Benjamin Behrooz

His answer isn't louder ads; it's layered, in-real-life touch points. A smiling street team in branded t-shirts hands you something at your door. A geo-targeted meta ad hits you because of where you live. Show up at Venice Fest and the local events, and three to five brand exposures later a stranger feels comfortable calling. Phone spam is dead; presence wins.

CHAPTER 04

Market on the customer's terms — not your ego

The fastest way to waste a marketing budget, Benjamin argues, is to sell what you're proud of instead of what the customer needs. Nobody wakes up wanting your AI services or your SEO package — they want their calendar to work, their phone to ring, their specific pain to stop. Meet them there, hold onto them for ninety to a hundred and twenty days with a QR code and retargeting, and you win on their terms.

“Go into the market on your customers’ terms. What are their pain points? What are they worried about? Just because you have AI services, they don’t give a damn — but they may want their calendar to work better.”

— Benjamin Behrooz

That’s also his hottest take on branding itself. The biggest mistake owners make is building for their own ego — a product they find masterful that solves no real problem. Perception is the whole game: name the problem you solve and how you help, or don’t bother opening the doors.

“The biggest mistake? Creating it for yourself and not your customer. Perception is key. What problem are you solving, and how are you helping your customer? Because if you’re not doing that, you should just shut down the business now.”

— Benjamin Behrooz

CHAPTER 05

noagentlist.com — the Robin Hood of real estate

Twelve months in the making, noagentlist.com is Benjamin's bet on how people will actually buy homes: from their fingertips, not a chauffeured tour. He calls it the Robin Hood of real estate, built to hand everyday families the off-market tools that Fortune 500 investors quietly pay \$500 to \$1,000 a month to use.

"We are the Robin Hood of real estate."

— Benjamin Behrooz

The pitch is access. Most buyers only ever see the roughly 10% of homes that are on-market; his platform opens up the other 90% — auctions, pre-foreclosures, high-remodel-value deals — and even grades properties so an A-plus find is obvious without calling an agent. The point is to stop families from bleeding four to six percent to a middleman they may not need.

CHAPTER 06

The AI silver lining

For all the fear around AI, Benjamin's favorite thing about it is almost boring: it searches and sorts, fast. In business since 2007, he watches AI surface the parts of his history he could never fully broadcast himself — the NYPD toy drive, the Shriners Hospital donations, the annual Santa Monica beach cleanup, the Fox News spot at his New York medical spa.

“AI is that friend that asks those eight additional questions.”

— Benjamin Behrooz

He describes AI as the friend who asks the eight additional questions — rewarding companies that are genuinely visible and doing the work, and quietly erasing the ones faking it with mass websites and no real social proof. He also warns against the flip side: letting an unqualified hire just “look at Claude and respond.” Control the machine, don't let it control you. If you've built a real history, this is the moment it finally gets its flowers.

IDEAS WORTH STEALING

Seven takeaways

- 01** Empathy is the moat — the one thing AI at scale still can't fake.
- 02** Every business has a back office; growth lives in the front office of visibility.
- 03** AI can't fix a roof — bet on blue-collar, then win it with layered IRL touch points.
- 04** Go to market on the customer's terms, not your service menu.
- 05** Build for the customer's problem, not your ego — or shut it down.
- 06** Bridge IRL to online: QR code → site → 90–120 days of retargeting.
- 07** Let AI surface your real history — genuine social proof beats a wall of fakes.

CONNECT

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noagentlist.com — off-market real-estate tools for everyone

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